We All Breathe the Same Air

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Draft: 1 — 31 October 2025
Format: Graphic novel script

Formatting Key

Element	Notation
Panel description	*Italics*
Narration	**NARRATOR:**
Spoken dialogue	**CHARACTER NAME:**
Thought bubble	**CHARACTER NAME** *(thinking):*
Sound effect	**SFX:**
No text on panel	*(No text)*

Acronyms

Acronym	Dutch	English
IND	Immigratie- en Naturalisatiedienst	Immigration and Naturalization Service
COA	Centraal Orgaan opvang Asielzoekers	Central Agency for Asylum Seekers
AZC	Asielzoekerscentrum	Asylum Seekers Center
AMV	Alleenstaande Minderjarige Vreemdeling	Unaccompanied Minor Asylum Seeker

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Page 3 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *Establishing shot of Schiphol Airport.*

NARRATOR: Schiphol. The air was heavy with stories I didn't want to tell.

Panel 2. *Frontal shot of Sam.*

NARRATOR: I was swallowed up and locked away. Walls whispered in a foreign language.

Panel 2B. *Close-up of Sam's eyes, looking frightened.*

SAM: And then I saw that dog.

Panel 3. *Frontal shot of the dog with a guard.*

NARRATOR: He looked at me as if he knew what secrets I carried with me.

Panel 4. *Close-up of passport with the dog and guard in the background.*

GUARD *(upper left):* Passport please...

NARRATOR: Welcome to freedom, I thought.

GUARD *(upper right):* Wait here please. Something's not right.

NARRATOR: But even freedom has its guards.

Page 4 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot of the corridor. Sam and the guard seen from behind, walking through a dark hallway.*

NARRATOR: And then the belly of Schiphol swallowed me whole. Black corridors.

Panel 2. *Shot of an empty interrogation room.*

NARRATOR: Darker than my fear.

Panel 3. *Shot of Sam alone in the interrogation room.*

NARRATOR: Time leaked away slowly. Drop by drop.

NARRATOR: I had never felt so alone.

Page 5 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *An IND officer enters the interrogation room.*

NARRATOR: Even when I was finally no longer alone in this room.

Panel 2. *Sam and the IND officer sit facing each other.*

NARRATOR: His smile was gentle, but his questions were not.

IND OFFICER: Where are you from?

Panel 3. *Medium close shot of Sam.*

IND OFFICER *(off screen):* How did you get here?

SAM: ...

Panel 4. *Medium close of the IND officer, over Sam's shoulder.*

IND OFFICER: If you don't say anything, I cannot help you...

Panel 5. *Profile shot of Yilmaz and Sam.*

NARRATOR: In my head I heard Yilmaz.

YILMAZ: Hold on. No words, no mistakes. Every second of silence is one step further from being sent back.

NARRATOR: The man kept asking. I kept silent.

Page 6 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot of the corridor. Sam and the guard from behind.*

NARRATOR: After about an hour of saying nothing...

Panel 2. *Full shot of the detention room. Guard, Sam, a Bangladeshi man, a Somali woman with a child.*

NARRATOR: ...they brought me to a waiting room.

NARRATOR: The air in the room was heavy with fear and uncertain silence.

Panel 2B. *Sam, the Bangladeshi man, and the Somali woman with her child sit in the waiting room.*

NARRATOR: We sat together, but everyone was utterly alone. Even the child didn't dare say a word. Each person's fear a mirror for the other.

Panel 3. *Sam, the Bangladeshi man, and the Somali woman with her child look at a guard with a dog.*

NARRATOR: After what felt like an eternity, another guard appeared with a dog. I don't know who was more afraid of the dog — the child or me.

Panel 4. *Sam is pushed into a van.*

NARRATOR: They put us in a cold bus. With windows that concealed more than they revealed. My heart was pounding in my throat.

SAM *(thinking):* Fuck, they're sending me back!

Page 7 *(7 panels)*

Panel 1. *Over-the-shoulder shot from the back of the bus. Sam looks over his shoulder.*

NARRATOR: While the engine growled softly, my thoughts were screaming.

SAM *(thinking):* No, no, no. Where are we going?

Panel 2. *Helicopter shot of the highway with the shadow of an airplane.*

NARRATOR: Every few minutes a plane roared over us. Their shadows a harbinger of my fate.

Panel 3. *Sam looks out the window.*

SAM *(thinking):* Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.

Panel 4. *Sam and the Somali man look out the rear window of the bus.*

NARRATOR: Then the bus took an exit. Slowly, the planes flying overhead grew smaller.

Panel 5. *Overhead extreme wide shot of the bus on the highway.*

Panel 6. *Extreme wide. The van on the highway heading toward a tunnel.*

NARRATOR: For a moment we felt relief. But everyone remained silent and afraid.

SAM *(thinking):* We're going somewhere else. But where?

Panel 7. *Close-up of Sam.*

Page 8 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Close-up of a military police officer.*

NARRATOR: They brought us to a dark building.

MILITARY POLICE OFFICER: Take off your clothes.

Panel 2. *Medium full shot. Sam undresses.*

NARRATOR: And there I stood. Completely naked. Wrapped in nothing but fear.

Panel 3. *Over Sam's shoulder — he is naked. The military police officer and IND worker face the camera.*

NARRATOR: Words weren't necessary. The officer's stern gaze and his weapon said enough.

Panel 4. *The officer searches Sam.*

NARRATOR: They searched everything. Everything...

Panel 5. *Close-up, over Sam's shoulder.*

NARRATOR: As the cold closed around my body, I felt shame burning. But I said nothing. My silence was the only thing I had left.

Panel 6. *Wide full shot of Sam, naked, alone in the room.*

NARRATOR: After the inspection they left me alone in the room. A piece of my dignity was left behind there.

Page 9 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Cell door opens.*

Panel 2. *Guard escorts Sam into the cell.*

NARRATOR: They threw me into a cell.

Panel 3. *Top-down shot of Sam in the cell.*

NARRATOR: A bare, empty space. But filled with the voices and thoughts of those who had been here before me.

Panel 4. *Full shot. Profile of Sam in the cell.*

NARRATOR: The walls spoke. Raw stories whose endings I would never know.

Panel 5. *Medium close, Sam facing camera in the cell. Each line in its own speech balloon coming from a different corner.*

WALL: What am I doing here?

WALL: I want to go to America.

WALL: I want my mother.

Panel 6. *Close-up of Sam.*

NARRATOR: I read every sentence and listened to every story. It moved me deeply. What had become of those desperate wishes? What would become of me?

Page 10 *(1 panel)*

(No text)

Page 11 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Sam sits curled up in the cell.*

NARRATOR: The loss, the fear, the longing, and the sorrow of every story reflected all the fear I carried with me.

NARRATOR: It exhausted me completely.

Page 12 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *Bus stops in front of a building with a Dutch flag.*

NARRATOR: The next day they brought me to a soulless building.

Panel 2. *Sam steps out of the bus.*

NARRATOR: A place of staying or disappearing.

Panel 3. *Wide shot of a corridor.*

NARRATOR: Inside, the cold air was stiff with rules.

Panel 4. *Wide profile shot — guard, Sam, and another man walk through the corridor.*

NARRATOR: All the staff, men and women, had the same stern look. And every new person told me what was not allowed.

Panel 5. *Medium close. Sam is dropped off at the dormitory.*

NARRATOR: At the dormitory I was dropped off. And for a moment, I didn't have to listen to all the rules.

Page 13 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Shot of the dormitory.*

NARRATOR: A large hall with bunk beds. In every bed a stranger with his own story, with whom I would have to share the night.

Panel 2. *Sam lies in bed with a hundred-dollar bill.*

NARRATOR: I felt so small and invisible. Invisible but vulnerable. The only thing I had was a hundred-dollar bill.

Panel 3.

NARRATOR: A gift from my mother. I hid it under my pillow as if it would protect me.

Panel 4. *Sam lies in bed.*

NARRATOR: I tried to sleep. But every sound felt like danger, and every shadow felt like a threat.

Page 14 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Sam clings to the bars. Hands with money.*

NARRATOR: The few hours that I slept...

Page 15 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Yilmaz stands holding a "Welcome to the Netherlands" sign.*

NARRATOR: ...were filled with confusing dreams.

Page 16 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *IND officer with a skull face.*

(No text)

Page 17 *(7 panels)*

Panel 1. *Close-up of a COA (Central Agency for Asylum Seekers) worker.*

COA WORKER: Psst, hey. Wake up. Wake up.

Panel 2. *Medium close. COA worker by the bunk bed.*

NARRATOR: Far too early to be woken up.

COA WORKER: Come with me please?

Panel 3. *Full shot. COA worker and Sam walk through a corridor.*

NARRATOR: Without saying a word, I did what was asked of me.

Panel 4. *Medium close, frontal. Sam — mugshot pose.*

NARRATOR: I had to have my photo taken.

Panel 5. *Wide. Sam stands with three COA workers in a small office.*

Panel 5B. *Extreme close-up of Sam's eyes blinking from the flash.*

NARRATOR: My face captured in a flash.

Panel 6. *Insert: yellow ID card.*

NARRATOR: A photo for a yellow card.

Panel 7. *Wide. Sam stands in the corridor with a worker holding a clipboard.*

NARRATOR: With a number that would from now on be my identity.

Page 18 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. Sam gets into a taxi — a Mercedes.*

NARRATOR: I was put in a taxi. A Mercedes-Benz!

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam sits with a man in the back seat of the taxi.*

NARRATOR: The sleek design and luxury of the car stood in stark contrast with my confusion.

Panel 3. *Medium close. Sam looks out the window.*

NARRATOR: In Iran I had never even seen a car like this...

Panel 4. *Wide. Shot of meadows and windmills.*

NARRATOR: And now I was riding in this dream car on a road I had no idea where it led.

Panel 5. *Extreme wide. Taxi drives on the highway.*

Panel 6. *Taxi arrives at the AZC (Asylum Seekers Center).*

TAXI DRIVER: The AZC. We're here.

NARRATOR: AZC? Was that the name of the street? The neighborhood? In any case, there were fences around it.

Page 19 *(8 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. Taxi parked in front of the AZC entrance.*

NARRATOR: I was dropped off in front of a large building.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam steps out of the Mercedes.*

NARRATOR: So this is what an AZC was?

Panel 3. *Close. A staff member receives Sam.*

NARRATOR: A friendly man was waiting for me.

Panel 4. *Wide. The staff member and Sam walk through a corridor.*

NARRATOR: I had only one thought that wouldn't let go of me.

Panel 5. *Close. Sam looks at the staff member.*

SAM: My mother. I need to call her.

Panel 6. *Medium close. Sam is on the phone.*

NARRATOR: The phone kept ringing and ringing. It took an eternity.

Panel 7. *Close. Sam's parents on the phone.*

NARRATOR: Two days of silence, during which my parents didn't know where I was. When she answered and heard my voice, her voice broke and I heard my father sigh with relief.

Panel 8. *Close. Sam smiles with the phone in his hand.*

NARRATOR: For the first time in days, I felt the ground beneath my feet again.

Page 20 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *Medium close. Sam and his guide stand with a woman.*

NARRATOR: I was handed over to another guide.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam and the woman walk through a corridor.*

NARRATOR: Who led me through a maze of hallways.

Panel 3. *Wide. Metal bars.*

NARRATOR: Everywhere, thick metal bars. I had ended up in an old prison.

Panel 4. *Medium close of Sam.*

NARRATOR: The architecture of the building has stayed with me forever.

Panel 5. *Extreme wide. The dome.*

NARRATOR: Gray. Heavy. Everywhere the echo of control and confinement.

Page 21 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam and the guide on a spiral staircase.*

NARRATOR: Every step I took in this building...

Panel 2. *Wide. Empty prison.*

NARRATOR: ...echoed off the cold walls.

Panel 3. *Wide. Sam and the guide stand in front of a door.*

GUIDE: We're putting you in a room with other people your age.

Panel 4. *Wide. The door.*

NARRATOR: Other unaccompanied minors.

Page 22 *(7 panels)*

Panel 1. *Medium close. The guide and Sam look into the room.*

NARRATOR: I had to share a room with two strangers.

Panel 2. *Medium close. The guide talks to Sam.*

NARRATOR: I had my own locker where I could keep my valuables. The woman warned me to keep a close eye on it.

Panel 3. *Wide. Three boys in the room.*

NARRATOR: None of my roommates were very talkative.

Panel 4. *Medium close. Sam looks in the locker.*

NARRATOR: In my locker, my predecessor had left something behind for me.

Panel 5. *Close. Sam looks dismayed.*

(No text)

Panel 6. *Insert: a moldy sandwich.*

(No text)

Panel 7. *Insert: Sam throws the sandwich away.*

(No text)

Page 23 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Medium close. Sam lies in bed.*

NARRATOR: That same night, all hell broke loose.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam gets up and walks to the gallery.*

NARRATOR: In the courtyard, sirens wailed through the night.

SFX: WEEEE-OOOOOO

Panel 3. *Full shot. Sam leans on the balustrade.*

SFX: WEEEE-OOOOOO

NARRATOR: Police were in the AZC.

Panel 4. *Close. Sam looks frightened.*

NARRATOR: A massive brawl.

SFX: WEEEE-OOOOOO

Panel 5. *Extreme wide. Panorama of the courtyard under the dome.*

NARRATOR: From all sides, residents threw everything they could get their hands on at the police.

Panel 6. *Wide. Police fight with residents.*

SFX: WEEEE-OOOOOO

Page 24 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Medium close. Residents look down.*

NARRATOR: In all different languages, people screamed at the police...

Panel 2. *Full shot. Residents throw things down.*

NARRATOR: And kept throwing things.

Panel 3. *Full shot. Police fight with residents.*

NARRATOR: And down below the fighting went on. And then I heard the dogs.

Panel 4. *Close. Sam looks terrified.*

NARRATOR: Their barking chased me back into a fear I already knew.

Page 25 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Dogs run along the balustrade.*

NARRATOR: As soon as the dogs were unleashed, everyone fled back to their rooms. I heard their running paws and their barking getting closer. Followed by the footsteps of the police. In Iran, stray dogs were something to avoid. But here, dogs were used as weapons. A force that drove us apart.

Page 26 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Sam stands with his back against the door.*

NARRATOR: Behind the closed door I felt the walls closing in on me. Fear gripped my heart. Where on earth had I ended up?

Page 27 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Close-up. Guard looks inside.*

NARRATOR: Finally, calm returned. But outside our door, we were still being watched.

Panel 2. *Full shot of the room. Sam alone on a bunk bed.*

NARRATOR: This was not what I had imagined the Netherlands to be. No peace, but a relentless storm.

Panel 3. *Sam lies in fetal position on the bed.*

NARRATOR: I thought of home. Of the place I had left behind. And of how far away that place now felt.

Page 28 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot of a classroom.*

NARRATOR: A few days later I had to go to school. Intake, Classification, and Introduction class — ICK class. The words sounded like unfamiliar songs. But mostly boring.

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sam sits in class. A woman in a pink shirt sits behind him.*

NARRATOR: Except for her. With her expressive eyes.

Panel 3. *Teacher writes on the blackboard.*

NARRATOR: Every time she smiled at me, it was as if the walls of the AZC ceased to exist.

Panel 4. *Insert: school bell.*

NARRATOR: When I could look at her, the class couldn't last long enough.

Page 29 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. Sam sits with her and Amir on a bench in the courtyard.*

NARRATOR: Thanks to her, I got to know other residents too.

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sam sits with her and Amir on a bench, facing camera.*

NARRATOR: Like Amir, with whom I talked about faith. He couldn't understand that I said I didn't believe.

Panel 3. *Medium close. Sam and Amir talk.*

NARRATOR: It made him angry, and because we were both stubborn...

Panel 4. *Full shot. Sam and Amir fight.*

NARRATOR: ...our first meeting ended in a fistfight.

Panel 5. *Amir laughs.*

NARRATOR: But that's how we eventually became friends.

Page 30 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam and the girl walk down the street.*

NARRATOR: One time after ICK class, we went into town together.

Panel 2. *Wide. Sam and the girl walk together along a house facade.*

NARRATOR: With the few words of Dutch we spoke, we tried to understand each other.

Panel 3. *Close. Sam and the girl look at each other.*

NARRATOR: Her voice was soft and her words stirred a feeling inside me I hadn't known before.

Panel 4. *Medium close. Sam and the girl hold hands in front of the dome.*

NARRATOR: When I was with her, the AZC didn't exist.

Panel 5. *Medium close. Sam and the girl lean in to kiss.*

NARRATOR: We felt safe with each other.

Panel 6. *Sam and the girl kiss.*

(No text)

Page 31 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. The girl lies on the bed. Sam pulls down her underwear.*

NARRATOR: First love. Clumsy.

Panel 2. *Close-up. Sam and the girl embrace.*

NARRATOR: But tender.

Panel 3. *The girl sits on top of Sam.*

NARRATOR: Real.

Page 32 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Top-down shot. Sam and the girl lie spooning.*

NARRATOR: For a moment, only we existed.

Panel 2. *Shot from outside the corridor.*

NARRATOR: In the middle of all the chaos.

Page 33 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam and the girl sit on a bench in the courtyard.*

NARRATOR: But our happiness was short-lived. She had to move to another AZC.

NARRATOR: Forcibly relocated.

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sam sits alone on the bench.*

NARRATOR: And I was left behind, with an emptiness that even my memories couldn't fill.

Page 34 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Over the shoulder. Sam sits across from an AMV (Unaccompanied Minor) counselor.*

AMV COUNSELOR: We've opened a bank account for you. There's 500 euros in it.

Panel 2. *Close-up of Sam.*

AMV COUNSELOR *(off screen):* For a bike. Clothes. School supplies.

NARRATOR: But I wasn't thinking about stuff.

Panel 3. *Extreme close-up. Insert: bank card.*

NARRATOR: Because with this bank card...

Panel 4. *Extreme wide. Sam at Haarlem Station.*

NARRATOR: I could go to Amsterdam.

NARRATOR: Finally, a feeling that resembled something like freedom.

Page 35 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Top-down shot. Sam boards the train.*

NARRATOR: 500 euros wasn't just money. It was an invitation to go on an adventure.

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sam sits on the train, looking out the window.*

NARRATOR: I could buy stuff some other time.

Panel 3. *POV: Sam looking out the window.*

NARRATOR: First, I was going to look for love.

Panel 4. *Extreme wide. Amsterdam Central Station.*

NARRATOR: Love in the middle of all the chaos.

Page 36 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Dam Square. Grim Reaper figure.*

NARRATOR: From the first step, Amsterdam opened itself like a theater full of wonder.

Panel 2. *Extreme wide. Canal houses (from the Damrak).*

NARRATOR: On every corner, a new story.

Page 37 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Coffee shop.*

NARRATOR: Amsterdam smelled strange. Was that the scent of freedom?

Panel 2. *Medium close. People smoking weed in front of the coffee shop.*

NARRATOR: All these people standing on the street, looking cool and nonchalant.

Panel 3. *Close-up. Sam picks up a joint from the street.*

NARRATOR: Someone threw away their joint.

Panel 4. *Close-up. Sam takes a drag from the joint.*

NARRATOR: I wanted to feel like that too. Cool and nonchalant.

Page 38 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme close-up. Sam's eyes.*

NARRATOR: Stoned for the first time.

Panel 2. *Close-up. Skull with a joint.*

NARRATOR: In a city that never stood still.

NARRATOR: For a moment, all my thoughts fell away.

Page 39 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Sam hallucinates his parents.*

NARRATOR: But suddenly my parents were there in my thoughts. Their faces and the sound of their voices. As if only at that moment I realized how much I missed them.

Page 40 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Sam sits alone on a bridge.*

NARRATOR: I believe I had never felt so lonely.

Page 41 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. People at an ATM.*

NARRATOR: I had to do something to drive away the loneliness.

Panel 2. *Close-up. Sam's hand puts the bank card into the ATM.*

NARRATOR: And then I felt the bank card in my pocket.

Panel 3. *Close-up. Sam's hand takes money from the ATM.*

NARRATOR: And I went looking.

Panel 4. *Full shot. Red-light district windows.*

NARRATOR: Looking for warmth.

Page 42 *(4 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam walks through the Red-light District.*

NARRATOR: The red light glowed on my skin. It made me insecure.

MAN: Looking for love?

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sex workers look on.*

NARRATOR: Women in their underwear looked at me playfully, trying to seduce me.

Panel 3. *POV: Sam, narrow alley.*

NARRATOR: But the red light started to burn.

Panel 4. *Wide. Sam buys a bike from a junkie.*

JUNKIE: Need a bike?

NARRATOR: I thought about my counselor and what the money was supposed to be for.

Page 43 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Sam on the bike.*

NARRATOR: I think I paid way too much for the bike because it rattled from every direction.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Profile of Sam on the bike.*

NARRATOR: But for the first time that day, I felt truly free.

Panel 3. *Extreme wide. Sam on the bike.*

Panel 4. *Full shot. Sam stands on the bike pedals.*

NARRATOR: The city rolled pleasantly...

Panel 5. *Close-up. Sam on the bike.*

NARRATOR: ...past beneath my rickety wheels.

Panel 6. *Close-up. Insert: wheel.*

Page 44 *(6 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam stands in front of a fries stand.*

NARRATOR: All that cycling had made me hungry.

Panel 2. *Extreme wide. Sam sits at the canal quay.*

NARRATOR: And while I was eating my fries...

Panel 3. *Close-up. A small bird.*

NARRATOR: I saw a sick little bird.

Panel 4. *Close-up. Sam holds the bird in his hand.*

NARRATOR: Without thinking, I started taking care of it.

Panel 5. *Medium close. Bird in the bike basket.*

NARRATOR: I decided to take the bird back to the AZC.

Panel 6. *Full shot. Sam walks with the bike.*

NARRATOR: Finally, I had something I could give love and warmth to.

Page 45 *(5 panels)*

Panel 1. *Extreme wide. Sam returns with the bike to the AZC.*

NARRATOR: Warmth and love was something I myself also craved in this cold place.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam.*

NARRATOR: But pets were strictly forbidden.

Panel 3. *Close-up. Bird tucked inside Sam's jacket.*

NARRATOR: So I had to smuggle the bird inside.

Panel 4. *Full shot. Sam in his room on the bed with the bird.*

NARRATOR: Once inside, I promised the little creature I would make him better.

Panel 5. *Close-up. The bird.*

NARRATOR: I would protect him.

Page 48

(This page appears in the original script with no text and no clear narrative function — noted by the author as uncertain. Page reserved for visual-only storytelling.)

Page 49 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. A woman and a boy jump into a swimming pool.*

NARRATOR: From that day on, I finally started to feel a little more at home.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Man in swim trunks with a bottle.*

NARRATOR: I made friends. Both inside and outside the AZC.

Panel 3. *Full shot. Sam underwater in the swimming pool.*

NARRATOR: And finally felt some freedom of movement in my life.

Page 50 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide. Sam with two friends in a changing room.*

NARRATOR: I started to build a steady group of friends.

Panel 2. *Medium full. Sam with friends.*

NARRATOR: Friends I could talk to about everything.

NARRATOR: But also with whom I could laugh endlessly.

Page 51 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Sam sits with friends at a table. A COA worker stands next to them.*

NARRATOR: But everything comes to an end.

COA WORKER: Sam Yazdanpanah Ardekani?

Panel 2. *Close-up of Sam.*

COA WORKER: You've been called in for your interview. With the IND.

NARRATOR: IND. One of the scariest words for any asylum seeker.

Page 52 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. A car drives.*

NARRATOR: One of my friends drove me to the interview.

Panel 2. *Medium full. Sam sits in an office with an IND officer.*

NARRATOR: I was terrified.

IND OFFICER: Tell me again — why did you leave Iran?

NARRATOR: She came across as cold and businesslike.

Panel 3. *Medium close. IND officer sits behind a desk.*

IND OFFICER: You've told us before, of course, but there are still some things that aren't clear.

NARRATOR: What should I do? Lie? Tell the truth? I didn't want to go back.

Page 53 *(3 panels)*

Panel 1. *Wide shot, black and white. School courtyard. Students in rigid rows.*

NARRATOR: There, where school felt like a military academy.

Panel 2.

NARRATOR: Where every day began with a sermon about piety and religion.

Panel 3.

NARRATOR: Where every time my hair was a little too long, I was forced to cut it short.

Page 54 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Sam sits with a young woman in a park. Morality police officers stand in front of them.*

NARRATOR: Where even meeting with a woman was forbidden.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Morality police take Sam away. The young woman cries.*

NARRATOR: And you'd be picked up by the morality police.

Page 55 *(7 panels)*

Panel 1. *Full shot. Line at the counter.*

NARRATOR: And back at the AZC, I also saw the desperation of my fellow residents.

COA WORKER: I'm sorry sir. You missed your stamp twice in a row now.

MAN: YOU CANNOT SEND ME AWAY!!

Panel 2. *Medium close. Angry man looks at the worker.*

IND WORKER: We warned you many times, sir.

Panel 3. *Close. Profile of the angry man.*

MAN: I have nowhere to go.

Panel 4. *Full shot. The man slashes his wrist.*

NARRATOR: This was not just desperation.

Panel 5. *Close-up. Wrist, razor blade.*

NARRATOR: But a scream in protest.

Panel 6. *Close-up. Worker screams.*

NARRATOR: Against the entire system.

Panel 7. *Full shot. The man lies on the floor. A medic applies a bandage.*

NARRATOR: And everyone standing in line understood this.

Page 56 *(1 panel)*

Panel 1. *Medium close. Sam sits with friends in front of a birthday cake.*

NARRATOR: Shortly after, it was my birthday. I turned 18. My friends had made a cake especially for me. They were beaming and laughing. I tried to be happy too, but that day I had received a letter from the IND. I hadn't opened it yet, because I didn't dare. But it was the only thing I could think about. Was it a coincidence that this letter had arrived on my 18th birthday of all days?

Page 57 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Sam sits alone in his dark room.*

NARRATOR: When the party was over and I finally had a moment alone...

Panel 2. *Full shot. Sam sits on the bed and reads the letter.*

NARRATOR: The moment of truth had arrived.

Page 58 *(2 panels)*

Panel 1. *Close-up of the letter.*

Immigration and Naturalization Service (IND)
P.O. Box 287
7600 AG Almelo

To:
Mr. S. Yazdanpanna [asylum seekers center address]

Date: 1 May 1998
Subject: Decision on your application for a fixed-term asylum residence permit

Dear Mr. Yazdanpanna,

On 3 March 1998 you submitted an application for a fixed-term asylum residence permit.

The Immigration and Naturalization Service (IND) has carefully assessed your application.

The IND has decided to reject your application. Your statements and the investigation do not demonstrate that upon return to Iran you face a real risk of persecution or inhumane treatment as referred to in Article 29, paragraph 1, of the Aliens Act 2000.

You are therefore not eligible for an asylum residence permit.

Departure from the Netherlands
You are not permitted to remain in the Netherlands. You must leave the Netherlands within 28 days of the date of this letter. If you do not leave within this period, an entry ban may be imposed.

Legal remedy
Do you disagree with this decision? You may file an objection with the IND within four weeks of the date of this letter. In your objection you must state why you disagree with this decision.

Closing
This decision was made on behalf of the State Secretary for Justice and Security.

Respectfully,
On behalf of the State Secretary for Justice and Security,
[official's signature]
Immigration and Naturalization Service officer

NARRATOR: Residence permit denied.

Panel 2. *Medium close. Sam with a bag over his shoulder.*

NARRATOR: The letter said I could still file an objection. But I decided to leave the AZC.

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Panel 1. *Medium close. Sam walks along the Amsterdam canals.*

NARRATOR: I traveled back to Amsterdam. To disappear into the anonymity of the big city. Into illegality.